University in Thiruvananthapuram on October 21 for violating UGC norms. The panel had recommended only one name instead of the three required. Citing the judgment, Khan issued notices to all 13 V-Cs who were appointed in a similar manner. On November 14, a division bench of the Kerala High Court quashed the appointment of K. Riji John as the V-C of the Kerala University of Fisheries and Ocean Sciences (KUFOS) on similar grounds.

Irked by Khan's relentless hounding on the issue, the Kerala government has decided to send him an ordinance, removing the governor as the chancellor of state universities. It has left Khan unperturbed. "I am yet to see it. If it comes, I will refer it to the President," he says.

Nor did the roaring protests in Thiruvananthapuram curb his enthusiasm. "Give me one instance where I have tried to interfere in the business of the government, and I shall resign that very moment. I can give you 1,001 examples where they interfered in the functioning of universities daily," he says. Khan is clear on one point. "All 13 V-C appointments in Kerala are illegal. They must go."

Indeed, the state government is not on very firm ground on the issue. "It is paying for bureaucratic faux pas in appointing V-Cs," is all that a senior bureaucrat could say in defence, speaking to INDIA TODAY. "Had the panel listed three names, the governor would have appointed the person the government preferred." By leaving the loophole, the Pinarayi regime has handed Khan a ready stick to beat it with, and help the BJP agenda. Never mind that governments are answerable to the electorate, not ceremonial heads. ■



Alok Shakya the new president of the Mainpuri district. And Dimple was a Thakur by caste before marriage."

And what of Shivpal, who has often chafed at nephew Akhilesh's takeover of the SP? Well, a source close to Shivpal says he had no option but to support Dimple. "Had he contested himself or fielded a candidate from his Pragatisheel Samajwadi Party (Lohia) against Dimple, he would have been perceived to be working against Mulayam's *bahu* just a few days after the leader's death. Shivpal's role in the election is significant, as his assembly constituency Jaswantnagar, from where he has been elected six times, falls under the Mainpuri Lok Sabha constituency."

But the truce, even if it be temporary, was effected honourably as Akhilesh and Dimple visited Shivpal in Saifai to seek his blessings. Shivpal relented and asked his party workers to ensure Dimple's victory. In a tweet after the meeting, Akhilesh said, "Along with the blessings of 'Netaji' and the elders of the family, the people of Mainpuri are also with us." He also shared a picture of the meeting.

**MANY SAY SHIVPAL HAD NO CHOICE BUT TO BACK DIMPLE, TO AVOID BEING SEEN AS BETRAYING NETAJI AFTER HIS DEATH**

If Dimple can replicate the massive wins Mulayam used to register—logging between 50-60 per cent of the votes—she can make Mainpuri her constituency in 2024, especially because she had lost from Kannauj in 2019. But it's going to be no walkover: the BJP's booth management and its plan to woo non-Yadav OBC voters are a challenge.

Aware of the significance of the Shakya vote, the saffron party is fielding Raghu Raj Shakya against Dimple. The Shakya vote adds up to nearly 300,000 in Mainpuri, the second highest after the Yadavs. Raghu Raj is perceived to be a Shivpal protégé, and the BJP was hoping that the PSPL chief might help him directly or indirectly.

The party is leaving no stone unturned in its plan to inflict a humiliating defeat on the SP in its own backyard. Defence minister Rajnath Singh is visiting, as are Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath, deputy CMs Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak. Other state ministers too will be setting up camp in Mainpuri. Nagendra Sikarwar, the BJP state general secretary for the Braj zone and also a key strategist for the Mainpuri seat, told INDIA TODAY, "Our preparations are going well. Our candidate is local and has a good people connect. The SP claims it has the support of Muslims and Yadavs, but we have the support of all communities. Even if you subtract the M-Y vote from the 17 lakh voters, we will still have the direct support of over 11 lakh voters. The BJP is the first choice of non-Yadav OBCs, which is why we secured such a huge majority in the assembly election. We have the support of Shakyas, Lodhs and Thakurs. Also, you can't discount the Modi and Yogi factors anywhere in UP."

The non-Yadav OBC vote is an obvious point of focus—it has asked all its top non-Yadav OBC leaders to hold public meetings in Mainpuri. Besides, the BJP is banking on forward caste and Dalit votes. It also makes light of the SP narrative of a united family. "Akhileshji remembered his uncle because of elections; this is called the fear of defeat," senior BJP leader Sidharth Nath Singh said. At the same time, BJP leaders are careful not to attack Shivpal, to keep their options open for 2024.

But Prof. Pankaj Kumar, who teaches political science at Allahabad University, does not see much hope for the BJP after the *chacha-bhatija* reunion. "Even if it's not a lasting one," he says, "it will yield the desired result for the bypoll. The Shakyas may have good numbers, but the Yadavs number over 4.5 lakh. And they are emotionally charged after Mulayam's death." What will matter is the margin. As for the BJP, while it goes all out, one eye is also set on the bigger prize: the 2024 election. ■